front as they carried a single banner reading: ‘We, the building workers, demand production quotas be lowered.’

By 10 am, they were marching shoulder-to-shoulder singing Bruder, zur Sonne, zur Freiheit!* across Alexanderplatz to Friedrichstraße, before tramping down Leipziger Straße, the wide street leading to the House of Ministries, where they demanded the termination of work quotas, an improvement in earnings and better working conditions. Some complained about exploitation and meaningless striving, and the constant round of obedience to authority, whether it be showing ID papers or meeting quotas. As protestors chanted, the furore was ratcheted up a notch when neither Walter Ulbricht nor Otto Grotewohl – who were both hidden away within the House of Ministries – refused to meet the marchers. (Throughout his career, Ulbricht never took the chance to confront those who despised him.) Watching events unfold, Czechoslovak diplomats saw demonstrators’ yelling slogans like, ‘Down with German-Soviet friendship,’ ‘Down with the government … Long live Western freedom.’; ‘We want a new government.’; ‘Long live the general strike … We want butter, not armed police.’ and ‘We want free elections in Berlin.’1 The Czechs also witnessed:

FDJ members in blue shirts threatened, and shouts were heard that they should take their shirts off and that they had outlived their time. The SED has sent all its functionaries among the demonstrators to try and win them over.

2

As the crowds swelled, the absence of clear orders from the administration baffled Russian officials. Only Fritz Selbmann, minister for heavy industry, attempted to quell the storm by addressing the crowd, but his speech was drowned-out by catcalls and curses. As the day wore on, there were also calls for a general strike. Then – in what must have been horrifying for